

# Saren Sakurai

(310) 570-7585 | [saren.sakurai@me.com](mailto:saren.sakurai@me.com) | [LinkedIn.com/in/saren](https://www.linkedin.com/in/saren) | [saren.ai](https://saren.ai)

## Demand Generation & Marketing Systems Leader | AI-Native MarketingOps

Systems thinker and marketing leader with 20+ years building the high-yield infrastructure that transforms demand generation from a craft into a predictable machine. Expert at architecting multi-channel GTM frameworks that convert complex B2B buying journeys into measurable pipeline. A proven turnaround operator called in to rebuild broken programs. Early adopter of production-grade AI workflows (AEO, LLM research) with a track record scaling revenue engines from Series A startups to a \$1.4B acquisition.

## Core Competencies

- **GTM Systems Design:** Architecting end-to-end demand infrastructure for high-growth B2B tech — funnel architecture, lifecycle staging, and campaign systems that convert long-cycle buying committees into measurable pipeline.
- **Turnaround Execution:** Rapid diagnostics and reconstruction of underperforming programs — post-M&A digital integration, SEM/SEO rebuilds, and CAC reduction through systematic funnel repair.
- **AI Integration & AEO:** Production-grade AI across the marketing stack — LLM-assisted persona research, agentic prospecting workflows, AI-accelerated content velocity, and zero-click search optimization (AEO).
- **MarketingOps & Data Governance:** CRM auditing and architecture (HubSpot/Salesforce), lead scoring and routing, speed-to-lead optimization, and multi-touch attribution tied to hard pipeline impact.
- **Executive & Team Leadership:** C-suite strategic partner with P&L-level budget ownership (\$2.3M paid media); led global teams and matrixed agency networks through high-stakes M&A integration.

## Professional Experience

### Wethos AI — Irvine, CA

Fractional Head of Marketing | Oct 2023 – Present

Own full-stack marketing for a post-stealth B2B SaaS platform, carrying it through a \$7.5M Series A growth phase.

- **Built GTM Foundation:** Developed the end-to-end marketing engine from scratch, establishing positioning, ICP messaging, lifecycle nurture, and the underlying analytics infrastructure.
- **Scaled Demand 344%:** Drove a 344% increase in lead growth via integrated paid, organic, and partner campaigns; instituted a rigorous test-and-learn operating cadence.
- **Optimized Paid Media Efficiency:** Reengineered paid media targeting, yielding a 2.2x CTR increase (0.74% to 1.63%) and 55% lower CPC on 81% less spend.
- **Engineered Funnel Conversions:** Led website + funnel rebuild (IA, messaging, CRO), driving a 3x lift in MQL→SQL conversion.
- **Established Measurement & RevOps:** Implemented the account's first conversion tracking (\$5.33 CPA benchmark for video-led demand) and deployed the HubSpot/Apollo/ZoomInfo stack with automated routing, scoring, and multi-touch attribution.

### Qwiet AI — Irvine, CA

Head of Growth | Jul 2023 – Dec 2023

Executed a high-velocity turnaround sprint to rebuild digital marketing for an enterprise AppSec startup.

- **Funnel Reconstruction:** Rebuilt the paid media and landing page architecture, slashing Google Ads CAC by 70% while accelerating pipeline creation.
- **Inbound Acceleration:** Grew inbound MQLs by 300% through highly targeted SEO and intent-data capture; launched an enterprise ABM pilot tailored to security buying centers.
- **Sales Alignment:** Partnered with Sales leadership to lock down ICP definitions, funnel stages, and strict SLAs to enforce cross-functional pipeline discipline.

## **BlackBerry (formerly Cylance) — Irvine, CA**

Senior Director of Marketing | Nov 2020 – Jan 2023

Acquired with the Cylance demand team following BlackBerry's \$1.4B acquisition. Inherited an underperforming global digital advertising program and led its complete strategic and technical reconstruction.

- **Paid Search Overhaul:** Rebuilt the global paid search program from the ground up—restructuring account architecture and keyword strategy to deliver a 550% YoY increase in paid search traffic.
- **Budget Management & ROI:** Directed a \$2.3M annual paid media budget across search, social, and programmatic, delivering an 8:1 ROI.
- **Conversion Optimization:** Established a systematic A/B testing and UX optimization program that generated a 33% conversion lift on core product pages.
- **SEO & ABM Scaling:** Increased organic traffic 40% YoY through comprehensive SEO strategy and content optimization, and scaled an advanced ABM framework to an 8x engagement lift using Demandbase and predictive analytics.

## **Cylance — Irvine, CA**

Director of Marketing | Jul 2017 – Nov 2020

Key driver of the hyper-growth demand engine leading up to the acquisition.

- **Pipeline Generation:** Generated \$4M in quarterly pipeline through the design and execution of highly integrated digital campaigns.
- **Funnel Governance:** Implemented the Forrester Demand Waterfall model, aligning marketing and sales around unified, transparent funnel metrics.

## **Additional Experience**

- **Head of Marketing (Fractional),** CloudKitchens — Los Angeles, CA (Jan–Jun 2023): Applied enterprise B2B demand generation and marketing operations practices to a high-growth food-tech platform.
- **Group Account Director,** Perficient Digital — Irvine, CA (2012–2017): Directed enterprise digital delivery for national clients across Adobe Experience Manager and Salesforce ecosystem rollouts.
- **Director of Client Service,** JUXT Interactive — Newport Beach, CA (2010–2012)
- **Management Supervisor,** AKQA — San Francisco, CA (2007–2010)
- **Web Producer** (Asia Pacific Region), Nike (via Aquent) — 2001–2007: Localized AKQA-built digital commerce and brand properties for Japan, Korea, China, and Taiwan markets.

## **Education**

**Bachelor of Arts in Liberal Arts** — Sarah Lawrence College, Bronxville, NY